

sister. At the age of 15, she was forced to take up sex work. "I had to look after my sister's five children and my brother's six children," says Madhu, who is now a peer coordinator with the Chaitanya Mahila Sangha in Jamkhandi taluk and helps fellow-former devadasis to take care of their health. Madhu says her group alone distributes thousands of condoms to women every month, besides conducting medical camps, etc.

Another case in point is Kalavathy, 38, who was just nine when she became a devadasi. She was 12 when she lost her virginity and at 14, she had a daughter. After extricating herself from the system, she has married her daughter off. As community leader, Kalavathy now speaks for the Mahila Sangha. The groups pool in money for emergencies and work towards dissuade people from following the devadasi system. "We also counsel women who indulge in sex work to take precaution, something we were not advised about in the early days," she says.

Mahila Sangha has also given

using the money she earned to send her children to school. Earlier, schools used to discriminate against the children of devadasis, but now, with the help of support groups, the women are able to educate their children. Most of the former devadasis now attend adult literacy classes themselves. "We have learnt to write our names," says Bhemmavva Madar, 34, who, along with her sister Renukavva, was dedicated to the system in her teens. Her children, Parasuram, 15, and Amaravathi, 12, do not know who their

ther, who works as a farm hand in the nearby paddy fields, which stay green thanks to the backwaters of the Almatti dam, says he had no choice but to dedicate his daughters to the temple as it was the custom. Now they make sheep pens from throwaway metal wires that their brother gathers from nearby cities. "We like earning for ourselves, but it would be a great help if we could get a house or financial support from the Government to secure our children's future," says Renukavva, mother of two.

BHEMMAVVA, 34
(left) and her sister Renukavva, dedicated to the goddess in their teens, make sheep pens for a living.

"Thanks to the night school, we have learnt to write our names now."



KALAVATHY, 38
(centre) became a devadasi at the age of nine and lost her virginity at 12. She is now a community leader.

"We counsel women who indulge in sex work to take precaution."



Kalavathy and her colleagues access to micro-credit through about 50 self-help groups, helping them take up other vocations like craftwork and tailoring. As Sathyavathy puts it, "Earlier, banks would not give us loans, but thanks to the credibility of the micro-credit groups, we are now able to get loans." A group of 40 women, who contribute Rs 10 each every week, approaches the local co-operative bank for a loan of Rs 20,000 to set up a business. This is how Hema Madar, a former devadasi, bought buffalo and started a dairy business,

father is, but go to the local government school in Kaladige. Amaravathi, who has no idea about what her mother did for a living or what she is doing now, says, "If someone can fund my studies, I will study well and become the collector of the district. I want to improve the lot of the family."

Because money is tight and income irregular, Bhemmavva lives with her brothers and parents in a hamlet near Kaladige, which has been earmarked for the low-caste community. Twenty-two people live in her small, 600-sq ft mud house. Her fa-

The government is looking into the issue of ration cards to former devadasis under the Antyodaya Scheme, hostel facilities, jobs under the National Rural Employment Assurance Scheme, and allocation of houses to the women under the Rajiv Gandhi Housing Scheme.

As an economically depressed and socially undermined group of women turns destiny on its head, social acceptance, along with governmental support, can help herald a new future that is free of the taint of sex work and divine slavery.

With the help of support groups like Mahila Sangha, these women are able to educate their children now.